

See also: Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The Glorious Revolution and the English Bill of Rights 102–103 ■ The Declaration of the Rights of Man 118–119 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The Civil Rights Act 248–253



allowed women to keep their own money and property on marriage. Women were now paying taxes on businesses they owned but had no say in how taxes were spent.

Since the 1860s, there had been repeated efforts by campaigners and sympathetic parliamentarians for legislation that would extend the right to vote to women, but they were continually thwarted. Things changed with the outbreak of World War I in 1914. With so many men sent off to war, women

Suffragettes took to the streets campaigning for women's votes and publicizing forthcoming meetings, as in this photograph taken in Manhattan in around 1913.

were required to take on traditionally male jobs and responsibilities. Arguments against giving women the vote—such as them being the “weaker sex”—seemed absurd when around 2 million women had taken jobs previously held by men.

In 1918, Parliament finally passed the Representation of the People Act, which extended the vote not only to all men aged over 21, but also to women aged over 30.

Votes for all

The Act enfranchised an estimated 8.5 million women, who were able to vote for the first time in an election in December that year. And because the Parliament (Qualification of Women) Act had passed just weeks earlier, they were also able to vote for female candidates for the first time.

By then, women's suffrage had become a key issue around the world. New Zealand had already

Voting rights are initially only extended to **rich land-owning men**, keeping power in the hands of the select few.

Working men successfully argue that they should be **represented in Parliament**.

During World War I, many **women leave the domestic sphere** to fill traditionally male jobs.

The Representation of the People Act gives women over **30 the right to vote**.

forged ahead and, in 1893, became the first country to extend the right to vote to women. In 1920, the Nineteenth Amendment to the US Constitution allowed women to vote, and in 1928, Britain passed the Equal Franchise Act, giving all Britons over the age of 21 the right to vote regardless of class, wealth, and gender. ■

“Men ... have decided that it is entirely right and proper for men to fight for their liberties and their rights, but that it is not right and proper for women to fight for theirs.”

Emmeline Pankhurst
My Own Story, 1914